

Can Your Computer Run It?

Know what your hardware can run before downloading models

The first question most people ask about local AI is, "What model should I download?" The better question is, "What can my computer run comfortably?" Those two questions sound similar, but the word comfortably changes everything.

A model might technically load into memory and still be miserable to use. It may take minutes to start, produce tokens slowly enough that you can watch every word arrive, force the rest of Windows to swap to disk, or turn a thin laptop into a hand-warmer. Local AI is therefore less about satisfying a minimum specification and more about balancing four things: model size, available memory, compute performance and memory bandwidth.

The good news is that the range of usable hardware is wider than many people assume. LM Studio recommends 16GB or more of RAM on Windows and Apple Silicon Macs, while noting that 8GB Macs can still handle smaller models with modest context sizes. On Windows it recommends at least 4GB of dedi-